

RESISEI LAYLA

SIMAN 1

Torah as Companionship in a World of Toil

In a world of movement and distraction, Torah joins a person to the whole creation and provides the truest companionship; Shabbat reveals the rest beyond worldly toil.

Seif 1 - Torah as the Companion of Creation

Torah connects a person to all creation and sustains him through the toil and distraction of this world.

הָאָדָם בְּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה צָרִיךְ לְצוּתָא – **Man in this world needs companionship, (ו:)** – **just as they stated in Berakhot (6b): "כל העולם כולו לא נברא אלא לצנת לזה," – "The entire world was created solely to accompany this one,"** – **inferring from this that he requires the company of created beings. (עירובין נד²).** – **And our Sages of blessed memory taught (Eruvin 54a): "המהלך בדרך ואין לו לוויה יעסק בתורה," – "One who travels on the road without an escort should engage in Torah,"** – **and this entire world is termed 'walking on the road,' בעולם הזה – כְּמוֹ שְׁאָמְרוּ זְכוֹרֵנָם לְבִרְכָּה (סוֹטָה כא.)³ על פְּסוּק "בְּהִתְהַלֵּךְ תִּנְחָה וְגוֹמֵר" – בעולם הזה – as**

¹ **Berakhot 6b** — “The sum of the matter, when all has been heard: fear God and keep His commandments, for this is the whole man.” What is meant by “for this is the whole man”? R. Elazar said: The Holy One, blessed be He, said — the entire world was created only for the sake of this one. R. Abba bar Kahana said: This one is worth as much as the entire world. R. Shimon ben Azzai says — and some report it in the name of R. Shimon ben Zoma — the entire world was created only to be a companion to this one. **Rashi:** “Only for the sake of this one” — that is, in order that this one be created; and “to be a companion” he renders by the Old French for keeping a man company. **Maharsha:** By its plain sense the verse should have said “hear it all” in the imperative, as it goes on “fear God”; but since it says “all having been heard,” the verse is speaking in praise of the God-fearing man, and so the close of the verse, “for this is the whole man,” must be his praise as well. The three Sages therefore do not disagree — each took up one of the three worlds. “The entire world was created only for this one” takes in even the world of the angels, which was created for the sake of man, who has free choice, so that he might earn merit; “he is worth as much as the entire world” is said of the middle world; and “the entire world was created only to be a companion to him” of the lower world, created only to attend upon him and do his service, as Ben Zoma said, “Blessed is He who created all these to serve me.” **Maharal (Nesivos Olam, Nesiv Yiras Hashem 1):** R. Elazar’s “the entire world was created only for this one” means, as was said above, that the world was created for the sake of the fear of Heaven. He is “worth as much as the entire world” because creation is due to the world on one ground, that it is the totality of the world, and due to the God-fearing man on a second, that he makes himself an effect subordinate to his Cause; the two grounds are equal, and so the two are equal. Ben Azzai held that neither may be said, for the Holy One, blessed be He, surely willed to create the world in its own right; rather the God-fearing man is the essence of the creation, being the effect for whom creation is fitting, and the rest of the world was created for his sake.

² **Eruvin 54a** — R. Yehoshua ben Levi said: One who walks along the road and has no escort with him should occupy himself with Torah, as it is stated: “For they shall be a graceful wreath [livyat chen] for your head” (Proverbs 1:9). **Maharsha:** “For they shall be a graceful wreath [livyat chen]” — occupation with Torah gives him grace upon the road in the eyes of all who see him, as we say in the Wayfarer’s Prayer, “and grant us grace and kindness ... in Your eyes and in the eyes of all who see us.” **Maharal (Tiferes Yisrael, ch. 62):** One who walks the road needs an escort because he departs from settled habitation, which is the very substance of existence, for “He did not create it a waste, He formed it to be inhabited”; where existence is not, he has cause to fear that he will come to non-existence, and this is why they said that all roads are presumed dangerous. Now the Torah is the order of existence, so that when a man occupies himself with it he is joined and attached to that order, and it is this that guards him from all evil, that nothing outside the order should befall him. Therefore they said that if he has no escort he should occupy himself with Torah, for then he will certainly not be in danger.

³ **Sotah 21a** — And [Scripture compared] the Torah to light, to tell you: just as light protects forever, so the Torah protects forever. And it says: “When you walk it shall lead you; when you lie down it shall watch over you; and when you awake it shall talk with you” (Proverbs 6:22). “When you walk it shall lead you” — this is in this world. “When you lie down it shall watch over you” — this is death. “And when you awake it shall talk with you” — this is in the time to come. **Rashi:** “It shall talk with you” — it will plead your merit on your behalf. **Maharsha:** This verse, which immediately precedes “For the commandment is a lamp and the Torah is light,” also speaks of the Torah and teaches that it protects forever: in this world “it shall lead you” — in the sense of giving you rest from all troubles; when you lie in the grave “it shall watch over you” against the beating of the grave; and in the World to Come “it shall talk with you,” pleading on your behalf against the judgment of Gehinnom. As for Tosafot’s difficulty — that by the Gemara’s conclusion a mitzva too protects forever — a mitzva protects forever only in this world, whereas the Torah protects even in the World to Come from the judgment of Gehinnom, as the verse “and when you awake it shall talk with you” shows. **Maharal (Chiddushei Aggados, Sotah 21a):** The Torah is intellectual, and whatever is intellectual does not fall under time; therefore it protects forever, as befits that which is beyond time and has no change, whereas the mitzva, like everything physical, falls under time and comes to an end, and so protects only for the moment. And since light signifies complete existence — without light nothing has existence, which is why a blind man is considered as though dead — one who holds fast to the Torah, which is complete light, cannot be abandoned by it to nonexistence: in this world, where a man is a “walker” who has no rest and may do something that brings him to ruin, it leads him; after death, the time of

our Sages of blessed memory expounded (Sotah 21a) on the verse 'When you walk, it will lead you, etc.' — in this world. וְכִשְׁאַיִן לוֹ צְנוּתָא יַעֲסֵק בְּתוֹרָה. — **So when one lacks companionship, he should immerse himself in Torah,** — שְׁהוּא דְּפֻס מְעֻשָׁה בְּרֵאשִׁית וְשֵׁל כָּל הַנִּבְרָאִים, — **for it is the blueprint of Creation and of all created beings,** — כְּמוֹ שְׁאַמְרוּ בְּבִרְאשִׁית רַבָּה פְּרָשָׁה א, — **as they said in Bereishit Rabbah (parashah 1),** — וְנִמְצָא יֵשׁ לוֹ צְנוּתָא שֶׁל כָּל הַבְּרִיאָה וְכָל הָעוֹלָם כֻּלּוֹ, — **and it turns out that he has the companionship of all Creation and the entire world.** וְיִלְכֹךְ נִקְרָא עוֹלָם הַזֶּה "בְּהִתְהַלֵּכְךָ", — **For this reason this world is called 'when you walk,'** — דְּהִילוּךְ רָצָה לוֹמַר טְרַדָּא, — **since walking signifies preoccupation,** (יא⁴), — כְּמוֹ שְׁאַמְרוּ בְּבִרְכּוֹת (יא⁴), — **as they stated in Berakhot (11a):** "הָא טְרַדָּא דְּמִצְוָה", — **'When you walk, etc.' — this refers to preoccupation with a mitzvah.** — וְעוֹלָם הַזֶּה כֻּלּוֹ טְרַדָּא, — **And this world is entirely preoccupation,** דְּלִכְּנָן וְלִכְּנָאֲרוֹ — **which is why the day of death is called in the Talmud 'his soul rested,' meaning he rested from his toil,** — כִּי אָדָם לְעֵמֶל יוֹלֵד, — **for 'man is born to toil.'** — **And therefore they said in the Yerushalmi (Berakhot 2:4, 17b):** — בִּירוּשָׁלַיִם (פֶּרֶק ב' בְּבִרְכּוֹת הֶלְכָה ד', יז⁵): — **'In all my days, I never achieved full concentration,'** — "אֲנִי מִן יוֹמִי לֹא כְּנוּנִיתָא"

dissolution, it guards him from loss and gives him existence; and in the time to come, when he returns to life, it gives him speech, which is life — "it shall talk with you." *Rav Tzadok (Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah 10)*: Death stems from the first corruption of Adam, and its repair is through occupation with words of Torah, of which it is said: "When you walk it shall lead you" — this is this world; "when you lie down it shall watch over you" — this is death; "and when you awake it shall talk with you" — in the time to come. For then, at the resurrection of the dead, the clarification will be complete, [showing] that death was only like sleep in this world, as the Sages called death "when he lay down to sleep," and the dew of Torah revives him. *Rav Tzadok (Yisrael Kedoshim 7)*: The world is full of turmoil and has no rest; therefore they said, "When you walk it shall lead you" — in this world, for this world is the time of walking, since "man is born to toil." But there are those whose toil is with knowledge and skill in deed, and whose walking is in holiness. The angels are called "standing," for they remain on the one level at which they were created, but man walks constantly from level to level and has no rest, like the righteous mentioned above — and this is truly the ultimate rest. *Beis Yaakov (Vayeishev 5)*: One who has no words of Torah has none of the good itself, for through words of Torah a person is awakened to all good things, as they expounded: "When you walk it shall lead you" — in this world; "when you lie down it shall watch over you" — this is death; "and when you awake it shall talk with you" — in the time to come. In the time to come the Blessed One will fill the treasuries of Israel and reveal to their eyes the light hidden in the performance of the mitzvos, and then they will see that all the knowledge, intentions and lights Israel had in this world were like a dream compared to its interpretation.

⁴ **Berakhot 11a** — As it was taught: "When you sit in your house" — this excludes one who is engaged in a commandment; "and when you walk on the way" — this excludes a bridegroom. From here they said: One who marries a virgin is exempt, and one who marries a widow is obligated. ... If so, even one who marries a widow [should be exempt]! — This one is preoccupied, and that one is not. If the exemption is on account of preoccupation, then even one whose ship sank at sea [should be exempt]! And should you say that is indeed so, why then did R. Abba bar Zavda say in the name of Rav: A mourner is obligated in all the commandments stated in the Torah except tefillin, since "splendor" is said of them, as it is said: "Bind your splendor upon you" (Ezekiel 24:17)? — There [the bridegroom] is preoccupied with the preoccupation of a commandment; here [the mourner] is preoccupied with the preoccupation of an optional matter. *Rashi*: Rashi explains that the bridegroom needed a verse of his own because the exclusion drawn from "in your house" removes only one busy with the actual work of a commandment, while the bridegroom's is an occupation of the mind alone — he is thinking about the consummation of the marriage. On the resolution at the end: since all we are deriving here is an exclusion — "excluding a bridegroom" — it is enough that what the verse excludes be a preoccupation belonging to a commandment [and not preoccupation of every kind]. *Rav Tzadok (Likutei Ma'amarim, festival discourses 13)*: One kind of sinking into forgetfulness of the Blessed One comes through the power of action — zeal and excessive effort in worldly affairs, the rich man with his money and trade, the ruler with his rule — until a man has not a moment's rest to take time to remember the Blessed One, for he is preoccupied and confused by his affairs. This is called Ashur, for Ashur denotes strength and power and also way and walking, which is preoccupation, as the Sages said on the verse "and when you walk on the way" that he is preoccupied.

⁵ **Jerusalem Talmud Berakhot 2:4** — R. Yirmiah said in the name of R. Elazar: One who prayed and did not direct his heart — if he knows that he can go back and direct his heart, let him pray; and if not, let him not pray. R. Chiya the Great said: I have never in my days had proper intention. Once I sought to concentrate, and my mind wandered and I said: Who enters before the king first, the arkafta [a Persian official] or the Exilarch? Shmuel said: I counted chicks. R. Bun bar Chiya said: I counted courses of masonry. *Pnei Moshe (s.v. "I have never in my days had proper intention")*: It was because he was preoccupied with meditating upon Torah — and so with all those that follow. The "arkafta" is the alkafta, an official who ranks above the Exilarch, and his musing was whether those admitted before the king are presented from the lower rank upward or from the higher downward, since the alkafta precedes the Exilarch. "Courses of masonry" are courses of a building.

שם, כְּדֵאִיתָא בְּכִרְכּוֹת שָׁם – **because preoccupation is the antithesis of focused intention, as brought in Berakhot there**, וְלִכְךָ אֵי אֶפְשָׁר כְּנִגְהָ שְׁלִימָה בְּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה כָּלֵל – **and hence complete intention is wholly impossible in this world.** וְלִכְךָ נִקְרָא שַׁבָּת "מַעֲיֵן עוֹלָם הַבָּא" שֶׁהוּא יוֹם מְנוּחָה – **Therefore Shabbat is called 'a semblance of the World to Come,' being a day of rest,** וְעוֹלָם הַזֶּה זְמַן הַטָּרְחָה – **whereas this world is the era of labor,** "כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ (עֲבוּדָה זָרָה ג.)": "מִי שֶׁטָּרַח בְּעֶרֶב שַׁבָּת וְכוּלֵי, 'He who toiled on the eve of Shabbat, etc.'

⁶ **Avodah Zarah 3a** — They said before Him: Master of the Universe, give it to us anew and we will perform it. The Holy One, blessed be He, said to them: Fools of the world! One who toiled on the eve of Shabbat will eat on Shabbat; one who did not toil on the eve of Shabbat — from where will he eat on Shabbat? **Rashi**: "On the eve of Shabbat" means in this world. **Maharal (Chiddushei Aggados, Avodah Zarah 3a, s.v. "and sukkah is its name")**: Since the nations claim to be fit for the Torah, which is intellectual and beyond nature, He gave them the commandment that shows a person going out of his nature: leaving his fixed, natural dwelling to sit in the shade of the sukkah. The nations, whose whole conduct is natural, cannot bear this and kick at it; Israel too are somewhat natural, for man is not an angel, and are exempt from the sukkah when it causes them suffering, yet they do not kick, for they desire and love to go beyond nature, only that at such times it is impossible for them. This shows that the Torah, the whole of which is beyond nature, is not fit for the nations at all. **Maharal (Chiddushei Aggados, Avodah Zarah 3a, s.v. "one who toiled on the eve of Shabbat")**: That is, this world is the physical world, which is always in potential, and therefore commandments and good deeds belong to it, for in it things go out from potential into actuality. But in the World to Come a person is already in actuality, and going out into actuality has no place there, since it is not physical; the World to Come is therefore cessation and rest. Hence he said that one who toiled on the eve of Shabbat, the day of action, will eat on Shabbat, the day of rest, on which nothing goes out into actuality — and so the commandments pertain to this world alone. **Rav Tzadok (Kometz HaMinchah, part II 25)**: Shabbat is [the day on which God Himself is one's light, needing no fire of fear]; nevertheless one must toil to cook the food on the eve of Shabbat, for "one who did not toil on the eve of Shabbat, what will he eat on Shabbat?" and "today to do them and tomorrow to receive their reward": this light does not come to a person by itself. So too the Shabbat lamp must be lit from the eve of Shabbat, for on Shabbat there is no longer time to arouse fear, the day being entirely love and cleaving to God. **Rav Tzadok (Machshavos Charutz 17)**: This world is the world of toil, and "one who toiled on the eve of Shabbat will eat on Shabbat" refers to the world to come, the day that is entirely Shabbat, where there is no doing even of Torah and mitzvot, as they said, "today to do them and tomorrow to receive their reward"; and Shabbat is a semblance of the world to come, the time of the Blessed One's rest. **Mei HaShilouch (vol. II, Sukkah)**: Shabbat alludes to the future, when there will be no labor, but only what a person acquired in this world through his deeds will then be fixed in his heart, according to how much he toiled in this world. Therefore all labors are forbidden on Shabbat in this world, and only what one toiled for on the eve of Shabbat does one eat on Shabbat. **Beis Yaakov (Vayeishev 3)**: All the possession a person acquires for himself in the world of action comes only from performing the mitzvot, and clarity [of understanding] alone does not suffice; by this he acquires the life of the world to come, for this world is like the eve of Shabbat and the world to come like Shabbat, and "one who toiled on the eve of Shabbat will have what to eat on Shabbat." **Tiferes Yosef (Shemini Atzeres 4)**: A person calls his labor "toil" only where he does not see its purpose; on Shabbat he attains the light of the Blessed One and recognizes that he attained it through the work of the six days. This is "one who toiled on the eve of Shabbat will eat on Shabbat": through the toil and labor he expended he attains this light, and so he recognizes retroactively that all the activity of the six weekdays was not futile toil for him either. **Sod Yesharim (Sukkos 18)**: In the future the nations will want to begin from the start, without first entering the gate of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, and the Blessed One answers that this is impossible: "one who toiled on the eve of Shabbat" means that had they first refined themselves to be included in Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, within "every citizen in Israel" [which includes converts], they too could have kept the mitzvah of sukkah. But to begin now without that prior inclusion is impossible, for one who did not toil on the eve of Shabbat has nothing to eat on Shabbat, and from where would he gain a share in the mitzvah of sukkah?

RESISEI LAYLA
SIMAN 2

Intellect, Will, and the Gathering of the Soul

The mind and heart shape one another; sin fragments their powers, while divine help gathers the scattered faculties of the soul into integrated righteousness.

Seif 1 - Intellect, Will, and Inner Integration

Mind and desire shape one another, while divine help gathers the soul's scattered powers into wholeness.

דלכנ אָמרו, – The intellect and the will are the two governors of man, – השקל והרצון הם שני מנהיגי האדם
 (ט¹): – which is why they said in the Yerushalmi at the end of the first
 chapter of Berakhot (9b): "אִי אֶת הַיָּב עֵינָא וְלִבָּא לִי, אֲנָא נִדְעָא דְאַתָּה דִּילִי" – 'If you give your eye and your
 heart to Me, I know that you are Mine.' – 'Eye' denotes the eyes of intellect,
 – yet they stated (Avodah Zarah 28b): 'The sinews of
 the eye are dependent on the heart,' – כִּי הָעֵיקָר הַלֵּב כִּי מִמֶּנּוּ תּוֹצְאוֹת חַיִּים – for the heart is primary, as
 'from it flow the springs of life.' – And intellect is drawn after desire, – וְהַשְׁקֵל נִמְשָׁךְ אַחֲרֵי הָרָצוֹן –
 כִּי הָרָצוֹן מִטָּה – as it is written (Exodus 23:8): 'For bribery blinds, etc.,' – כִּי הַשְׁחָד יַעְרֵר וְגוֹמֵר

¹ **Jerusalem Talmud Berakhot 1:5** — "You shall not commit adultery" corresponds to "You shall not stray after your heart and after your eyes" (Numbers 15:39). R. Levi said: The heart and the eye are the two agents of sin. It is written, "My son, give Me your heart, and let your eyes observe My ways" (Proverbs 23:26). The Holy One, blessed be He, said: If you give Me your heart and your eye, I know that you are Mine. **Pnei Moshe** (s.v. "It is written, 'My son, give Me your heart'"): He expounds "and your eyes" as belonging to what precedes it: if you give Me your heart and your eyes, then "they will observe My ways" — as he concludes, "The Holy One, blessed be He, said: If you give Me your heart and your eye, I know that you are Mine." **Rav Tzadok (Divrei Soferim 35)**: Because of the Yerushalmi's "if you give Me your eye and your heart, I know that you are Mine," they expounded "you shall guard yourself [from every evil thing]" as a warning against [impure] thoughts: even where such a thought incurs no punishment, the mitzvah of guarding one's heart rests upon him. For the essence of Jewishness is in the heart, and fear [of Heaven], the essence of what God asks of you, is only in the heart. **Rav Tzadok (Dover Tzedek, Kuntres Ner HaMitzvos 2)**: In the Yerushalmi's "if you give Me your eye and your heart," the eye is wisdom ("the wise man's eyes are in his head"; "who is wise? one who sees what will be born") and the heart is the understanding of the heart, the two powers by which a person overcomes his inclination and gives birth to a good deed; [the Yerushalmi] reverses the order of the verse "after your hearts and after your eyes." A person need give the Blessed One only these, while the completion comes from the Blessed One's help. **Rav Tzadok (Likutei Ma'amarim, festival discourses 10)**: Of the righteous man whose nature is not evil Ezekiel speaks in the future tense, yet "his eyes he did not lift" and "his neighbor's wife he did not defile" are in the past tense, for these are the two agents of which the Sages said, "if you give Me your eye and your heart, I know that you are Mine." Once he has handed these two over to the Blessed One in actual deed, through the effort of turning from evil when a transgression came his way and he was saved, he no longer needs effort in deed, only that his heart be ready to turn from evil and do good when the occasion comes. **Rav Tzadok (Pri Tzaddik, Kedushas HaShabbos 6)**: David, praised as "beautiful of eyes", was truly pure of all the filth of this world's desires, and this showed in the eyes, for the eye and the heart are the two agents of sin, and "if you give Me your eye and your heart, I know that you are Mine." The heart is hidden from all ("man sees with the eyes, but God sees into the heart"), whereas the eyes are in the open. **Rav Tzadok (Tzidkas HaTzaddik 190)**: The eye and the heart are the agents of sin, as the Yerushalmi says, and likewise agents for good, as it says there, "if you give Me your eye and your heart"; they are the two levels of seeing and knowing, of which it is said "Send Your light and Your truth," the essence of seeing being light. They are the levels of Jacob and Joseph: "truth to Jacob" and "light is sown for the righteous."

² **Avodah Zarah 28b** — There was a certain maidservant in the house of Mar Shmuel whose eye became inflamed on Shabbat. She cried out, and there was none who attended to her, and her eye burst. The next day Mar Shmuel went out and expounded: An eye that has rebelled — it is permitted to apply eye salve to it on Shabbat. What is the reason? Because the tendons of the eye are bound up with the understanding of the heart. **Rashi**: "An eye that has rebelled" — it seeks to come out [of its socket], like a man who rebels and goes out; and its being "bound up with the heart" means that the light of the eye is intertwined with and held fast in the membranes of the heart [so that the danger is to life itself]. **Tosafos** (s.v. "the tendons of the eye are bound up with the heart"): Rashi explains that the light of the eye depends on the membranes of the heart, but it seems rather that the reading is "upon the understanding of the heart" — that is, the eye's seeing depends upon the heart's understanding. Accordingly the word for "tendons" is spelled with a shin, from "I behold him," or with a samekh, from the expression "he surveys his property"; and "understanding" is with a bet, from the word for comprehension, as is said of the Chariot, "he would see with the understanding of the heart." **Rav Tzadok (Tzidkas HaTzaddik 190)**: Joseph [whose level is the eye] reported that his brothers "cast their eyes" [on the daughters of the land], for he held that "the tendons of the eye are bound up with the heart," as they also said, "a bride whose eyes are beautiful [needs no examination of her whole body]." But in truth the essence is the heart, "for from it are the issues of life," since in it lies the essence of vitality and of cleaving to the living God.

³ **Exodus 23:8** — And you shall take no bribe, for the bribe blinds the clear-sighted and perverts the words of the righteous. **Rashi**: "You shall take no bribe" — even in order to judge truthfully, and all the more so in order to pervert judgment, for the perverting of judgment is already forbidden elsewhere: "you shall not pervert justice." "It blinds the clear-sighted" — even one learned in Torah who takes a bribe will in the end have his mind confounded, forget his

– "נעל זה אִמְרו (יִזְמָא עב):⁴ לָמָּה זֶה מְחִיר וְגוֹמֵר וְלֵב אֵין. – because the will bends the intellect. – הַשְׁכֵּל.

Regarding this they said (Yoma 72b): "Why is there a purchase price... when there is no heart?"

עֵין רוֹאָה " – Nevertheless, they also said (Bemidbar Rabbah 10:2): – וּמִכָּל מְקוֹם אִמְרוּ גַם כֵּן (בְּמִדְבָּר רַבָּה י, ב⁵)
 – שֶׁהַשְּׁכֵל מוֹלִיד הַרְצוֹן. – 'The eye sees and the heart covets,' – וְנֵעַל זֶה אִמְרוּ (אֲבוֹת פְּרָק ג, יז)⁶ – And concerning this they taught (Avot 3:17): – "אִם אֵין חֵכְמָה אֵין יִרְאָה, יִרְאָה אֵין חֵכְמָה,
 – 'If there is no wisdom, there is no fear; if there is no fear, there is no wisdom,' – שְׁנֵיהֶם קְשׁוּרִים יַחַד זֶה בְּזֶה וְהָא בְּלֹא הָא לֹא סָגִי
 – 'And it is written: 'My father and my mother have forsaken me, etc.,' – וְיִתְּנָה אָבָא וְאִמָּא הוּא מוֹחָא וְלֵבָא – for as is known, 'father and mother' represent brain
 – וּשְׁנֵיהֶם עֲזָבוּנִי בְּעוֹנוֹת – and both abandon a person through sin: אֵין חֵכְמָה וְאֵין בִּינָה בְּעֵידֶן דִּינֶצֶר
 – there is neither wisdom nor understanding in the hour of the evil inclination, לִית דְּמְדַכְּר לִינֶצֶר טוֹב, הֶרֶע.

learning and lose the light of his eyes; and "the words of the righteous" means words that are just, true judgments.

⁴ **Yoma 72b** — R. Shmuel bar Nachmani said that R. Yonatan said: What is meant by "Why is there a price in the hand of a fool to buy wisdom, seeing he has no heart?" Woe to them, the enemies of the Torah scholars [that is, the scholars themselves], who occupy themselves with Torah and have no fear of Heaven in them. R. Yannai would proclaim: A pity for him who has no courtyard, yet makes a gate for his courtyard. **Rashi**: "Courtyard": a court. "And makes a gate for his courtyard": for the Torah is only a gate through which to enter into the fear of Heaven; therefore he must acquire the fear of Heaven first. **Maharsha** (s.v. "*seeing he has no heart*"): Taken plainly [the verse is difficult], for even one who has no heart to understand should study Torah, which "makes wise the simple"; therefore they said that a fool can certainly come to wisdom through study, but "he has no heart" means that it is not in his heart to fulfill it, only to acquire a name, as Rashi explains on the verse, that is, he has no fear of Heaven. **Maharal** (*Nesivos Olam, Nesiv Yiras Hashem 4*): Casting off the yoke of the fear of Heaven is graver in Torah scholars than in other men, since such a one knows his Maker and leads others to cast it off as well; hence "woe," for they were fit for a great and supreme level, and now that level is turned for them to evil, more so than for others. R. Yannai speaks of a scholar who is not careful in his deeds, though he does not sin outright, of whom one would not say "woe," yet it is "a pity": for Torah and wisdom are the gate by which one enters, while through the fear of Heaven a man has his dwelling with the Blessed One, as it is written, "The fear of the Lord is His treasure," so that the fear of Heaven is the house. One who has Torah without the fear of Heaven has made a gate where there is no house; his Torah is in vain, and he is further from the Blessed One than another man. **Rav Tzadok** (*Likutei Ma'amarim, on completing the Talmud 5*): "Why is there a price in the hand of a fool to acquire wisdom, seeing he has no heart" speaks of one who has Torah [without fear of Heaven]: lacking fear of Heaven, the fencing of the heart from evil desires, he wants to put his effort into wisdom alone, and of him they said, "whoever says he has only Torah does not have [even Torah]," for effort applies only below wisdom, not to wisdom itself. Through this he comes to deny the Oral Torah and believe only in the Written Torah.

⁵ **Bamidbar Rabbah 10:2** — "My son, give Me your heart, and let your eyes observe My ways" (Proverbs 23:26). What did the Holy One, blessed be He, see, that He asked of Israel the heart and the eyes, that they should follow after Him? Because transgression depends upon them, as it is written: "You shall not stray after your heart and after your eyes" (Numbers 15:39). The eye and the heart are the two agents of sin. "For a harlot is a deep pit" (Proverbs 23:27) — as Moses said, "after which you stray" (Numbers 15:39), to say that harlotry depends upon them: the eyes see the harlot, and the heart contemplates her. **Rav Tzadok** (*Likutei Ma'amarim, on Samson 16*): The Sages' words "the eye sees, the heart desires, and the organs of action complete [the deed]" describe three levels. Wisdom is the stage still at "the eye sees" alone, momentary and not yet spread through to the end, unlike prophecy, which has passed through all the levels and is fully possessed; yet wisdom is superior, in the manner of "better is the sight of the eyes than the wandering of the soul" (Ecclesiastes 6:9). **Rav Tzadok** (*Machshavos Charutz 1*): A thought that reaches the root of wisdom in the brain is joined to the understanding in the heart, so that it is at once felt in the heart and gives birth to the powers of action, as in "the eye sees, the heart desires, and the organs of action complete [the deed]"; for we find seeing associated with wisdom, as it is written, "my heart has seen much wisdom" (Ecclesiastes 1:16). **Mei HaShiloach** (vol. 1, *Tetzaveh*): The kapores corresponds to the heart and the menorah to the eyes, and these alone were of pure gold [without a core of acacia wood], because in them a person must be clean of any self-interest in this world, since "the eye and the heart are the two agents of sin: the eye sees and the heart desires." The eye should be stripped of all worldly desire and serve only as an instrument for the soul, like clear glass through which the soul looks at each thing and judges whether to accept it; but when the eye itself craves the delights of this world, it is no longer the soul's instrument but acts on its own and covets, and the soul cannot sort the good from the bad.

⁶ **Pirkei Avot 3:17** — R. Elazar ben Azariah said: Where there is no Torah, there is no proper conduct; where there is no proper conduct, there is no Torah. Where there is no wisdom, there is no fear [of Heaven]; where there is no fear, there is no wisdom. Where there is no understanding, there is no knowledge; where there is no knowledge, there is no understanding. Where there is no flour, there is no Torah; where there is no Torah, there is no flour.

(כְּמֹז שְׂאֵמְרוּ נְדָרִים לִבִּי) – **and none remembers the good inclination (as noted in Nedarim 32b)**, וְאֵין לָנוּ, – **Yet nonetheless**, שְׂכַל לֹא רָצוֹן. – **leaving us devoid of intellect and worthy will**. ה' יִאֲסֹפֵנִי. – **for the Holy One, blessed be He, assists man and prevails for him even in the final generations**, אֶמְרוּ לְאוֹמֶן שֶׁשָּׂשָׁאֲנִי כְמוֹעַר, – **similar to: 'Tell the artisan who made me, how ugly is, etc.'** (Ta'anit 20b); וְהִקְדוּשׁ (תַּעֲנִית כ:)

⁷ **Nedarim 32b** — Rami bar Abba said: What is meant by that which is written, "There was a little city, and few men within it"? "A little city" — this is the body; "and few men within it" — these are the limbs; "and there came a great king against it and besieged it" — this is the evil inclination; "and built great bulwarks against it" — these are the sins. "And there was found in it a poor wise man" — this is the good inclination; "and he by his wisdom delivered the city" — this is repentance and good deeds. "Yet no man remembered that same poor man" — for at the hour of the evil inclination there is none who calls the good inclination to mind. **Maharsha (s.v. "a little city")**: On the plain sense the verse should have said that the great king came against it with many men and his armies, for there is no king without a people — as it did say of the city itself, "and few men within it"; and "besieged it and built great bulwarks against it" implies that he did so by himself, without a people, which is not the way of a king. But according to the interpretation, the "great king" is the evil inclination, which itself surrounds the city — that is, the body — and itself builds against it; and "the men" Rashi explains in Ecclesiastes, following the interpretation, as a man's limbs, and so it is in the Midrash Rabbah. **Maharal (Nesivos Olam, Nesiv HaTochachah 2)**: The body is called a city, as they said of the verse "a little city and few men within it"; and the intellect within the body rules over the body and directs [its limbs] in what they are to do. **Rav Tzadok (Tzidkas HaTzaddik 220)**: As long as a person remembers the yoke of the kingdom of Heaven, of Torah and of the commandments upon him, he can easily rebuke the inclination and push away every alien thought; the inclination's work is to make him forget this, as they said, "at the hour of the evil inclination no one remembers the good inclination," as it says, "yet no man remembered" (Ecclesiastes 9:15), for then the good thoughts of the unity of the Creator are forgotten from the heart and none of them is recalled. For this is the commandment of tzitzis: to remind him. **Mei HaShiloach (vol. I, Vayeishev)**: "At the hour of the evil inclination no one remembers the good inclination": when the Blessed One wishes to test a person, He makes him forget the whole gravity of the prohibition in the matter in which He tests him. So it was with the brothers when they wished to kill Joseph: the prohibition was hidden from them, and he was saved only by counsel outside the law, Judah's worldly reasoning "What profit is it?"; as soon as they agreed not to kill him, they saw the gravity of the prohibition. **Beis Yaakov (Vayechi 23)**: Joseph the righteous is the "trace of life" that stays awake within the community of Israel, rousing their souls through his service so that they do not fall asleep in the darkness and concealment of this world. Thus, although the Gemara says, "at the hour of the evil inclination no one remembers the good inclination," Joseph does not let it be forgotten entirely, God forbid, but constantly reminds Israel. **Tiferes Yosef (Ki Savo 2)**: Going out "on the way" alludes to distraction, and one fears that amid the distraction he will forget the Blessed One, as "at the hour of the evil inclination no one remembers the good inclination." The counsel for this is "take counsel with your Maker and then go out": to accept the yoke of the kingdom of Heaven before entering the distraction, so that even in its midst he will not forget the Blessed One.

⁸ **Taanit 20a–20b** — Our Rabbis taught: A person should always be soft as a reed and not hard as a cedar. It once happened that R. Elazar son of R. Shimon was returning from Migdal Gedor, from the house of his teacher, riding on a donkey and making his way along the riverbank, and he was rejoicing greatly, and he felt himself lofty because he had learned much Torah. There chanced upon him a man who was exceedingly ugly, who said to him: "Peace be upon you, my master." He did not return his greeting. He said to him: "Empty one! How ugly is that man! Is everyone in your town as ugly as you?" He answered: "I do not know. But go and say to the Craftsman who made me — how ugly is this vessel You have made." When he realized that he had sinned, he dismounted from the donkey, prostrated himself before him and said: "I have wronged you; forgive me." He said: "I will not forgive you until you go to the Craftsman who made me and say to Him: how ugly is this vessel You have made." He walked behind him until he reached his city. The people of his city came out to greet him, saying: "Peace be upon you, my master, my master, my teacher, my teacher." He said to them: "Whom are you calling 'my master, my master'?" They said: "The one walking behind you." He said to them: "If this is a master, may there not be many like him in Israel." They said: "Why?" He told them what he had done to him. They said to him: "Even so, forgive him, for he is a great man in Torah." He said: "For your sakes I forgive him — provided he does not make a habit of acting this way." Immediately R. Elazar son of R. Shimon went in and expounded: A person should always be soft as a reed and not hard as a cedar; and it is for this reason that the reed merited that a quill be taken from it with which to write a Torah scroll, tefillin and mezuzot. **Rashi**: "Making his way": [strolling] for enjoyment. "There chanced upon him a man": some texts read, "Elijah, of blessed memory"; and he meant to rebuke him, so that he would not make a habit of the matter. **Tosafos (s.v. "there chanced upon him a man who was exceedingly ugly")**: In Tractate Derekh Eretz it is explained that this man was Elijah, and he meant it for good, so that [R. Elazar] would not make a habit of the matter. **Maharsha**: He called him "empty one" perhaps because, being exceedingly ugly and black, the man looked to him like a foreigner from Cush — hence "is everyone in your town [that is, in the land of Cush] as ugly as you?"; and he answered, "I do not know" — I cannot tell you that they are ugly, for Scripture did not speak disparagingly even of an unclean animal, since that imputes a defect to the creation; but you, in saying of me "how ugly," impute a defect to the creation, and to the Craftsman as well, who made an ugly vessel. "I have wronged you; forgive me" means: I confess that I did not speak well. "Provided he does not make a habit of acting

בְּלֹא, — **and the Holy One, blessed be He, is the artisan Who made us thus,** בְּרִיךְ הוּא הוּא אוֹמֵן שֶׁעָשָׂנוּ כֵּךְ — **without intellect, without understanding in the heart, and without holy desire.** "הוּא יִקְבֹּץ אֶת־נוֹצְרֵינוּ" — פִּירוּשׁ אֲסִיפָה הוּא קְבוּצַת הַנִּדְחִים. — **'He will gather us' — meaning gathering is the assembly of the dispersed, and that is the essence of salvation: 'and gather our dispersed, etc.,' — concerning each individual soul —** אִם יִקְוֶה צוֹ נִדְחֵיו, כֹּל — **if its scattered parts and all facets of its soul are reunited into one place, הוּא** — **צַדִּיק וְנוֹשָׁע. — it becomes righteous and redeemed.**

this way" cannot mean that he may do so now and then; rather: provided he does not do what habituates him to it — that his mind not be haughty, for that is what habituated him to speak disparagingly of people as he did. **Maharal (Nesivos Olam, Nesiv HaAnavah 7):** The name Migdal Gedor — "tower" and "fence" — found nowhere else, teaches that this was no sin of real pride in the righteous man: the Torah is high above all like a tower and set apart from the world like a fence set apart from the public domain, so its master naturally has a little pride, seeing himself as high and set apart from other creatures. But because R. Elazar was not sufficiently on guard against pride, he came to say "how ugly is this man," disparaging the creation, which is from the Blessed Name — unfitting for one great in Torah; had the man been born lacking an eye, which is not the way of the world, one could not say "go to the Craftsman who made me," but this man had no blemish, so his form was indeed the Craftsman's work. Knowing that he had sinned, he expounded that the scholar who has risen to the eminence of the Torah must be soft as a reed, which the higher it grows the more it bows its head, for it is soft; whereas the cedar, being hard, grows ever more erect the higher it rises. **Rav Tzadok (Pri Tzaddik, Ki Savo 10):** Elijah, the angel of the covenant, came upon R. Elazar b. R. Shimon in the guise of an "ugly" man, one flawed in the covenant, to rebuke him for disparaging such a person as though he were beyond hope. If such a person only sets his heart to improve his ways, he can repair all that has passed with this very plea, "go to the Craftsman who made me": after repentance it becomes clear that all that befell him was also from the will of the Blessed One, who created man with the evil inclination, which "overpowers him every day, and were it not for the Holy One, blessed be He, helping him, he could not withstand it." Not everyone may make this plea, God forbid, as license to do as his heart desires; only one who knows that all his attainments come from the Blessed One and not from his own strength may strengthen his heart with it after a stumbling. **Tiferes Yosef (Talmud Anthology, Ta'anis 16):** As his father explained: no creature may claim to be refined of himself, so a person must ascribe his own failing to himself even when he believes himself clean; but a failing he sees in his fellow he may not ascribe to him, and must judge him favorably, that he is surely clean of the bad traits that appear in him and the sin was "like an error that proceeds from the ruler." R. Elazar judged the man as unrefined, and the man answered: though I must lay the deficiency on myself, you have no right to lay it on me but must judge me favorably, so "go to the Craftsman who made me and say, How ugly is this vessel that You have made."

RESISEI LAYLA
SIMAN 3

Sleep, Soul, and Spiritual Exchange

Sleep resembles death and exposes the soul to spiritual exchange; entrusting oneself to Hashem through Bedtime Shema preserves and redirects these forces toward good.

RESISEI LAYLA
SIMAN 43

Life, Sustenance, Children, and Mazal

The three fundamental human needs are governed by exact justice as expressed through the soul's supernal root; prayer can reach that level and reshape its flow.

Seif 1 - Children, Life, Sustenance, and Mazal

Exact judgment governs the three basic human needs through the soul's supernal root known as mazal.

צורך האדם בעולם ידוע שהם שלשה דברים – **Man's fundamental needs in this world are known to be three things: life, the preservation of life—namely sustenance (mezonei)—** ואמר זכרונם. – **and continuity across generations—namely children (banei).** דלאו בזכותא תליא – **And our Sages of blessed memory stated (Moed Katan 28a): "the matter depends not on merit, but rather on mazal,"** – **and seemingly this contradicts what is explained in the Torah and in the words of our Sages in numerous places, דהכל במשפט, – that everything is governed by exact justice, ובראש השנה אדם נדון על כל פה, – and on Rosh Hashanah a person is judged regarding all of these, ומתפללין בכל יום תמיד על שלשה אלה, – and we pray every single day continually**

¹ **Moed Katan 28a** — Rava said: Length of life, children, and sustenance do not depend on merit but on fortune. For Rabbah and R. Chisda were both righteous sages: this one would pray and rain would come, and that one would pray and rain would come. R. Chisda lived ninety-two years, Rabbah lived forty. In R. Chisda's house there were sixty wedding feasts; in Rabbah's house, sixty bereavements. **Tosafos (s.v. "rather, it depends upon fortune"):** They asked in Tosafot: but we said at the end of Shabbat that "Israel is not subject to a constellation"! One may answer that sometimes a man's lot is changed, as in the cases there, and sometimes it is not changed — as is said in Taanit concerning R. Elazar ben Pedat, to whom it was said: Would it please you that I destroy the world, so that perhaps you might be created anew at an hour of sustenance? **Tosafos (s.v. "sixty wedding feasts"):** Some explain that the number is not meant exactly. **Maharsha (Chidushei Agadot, s.v. "it depends upon fortune"):** Tosafot's answer — and in Tosafot at Shabbat it is more explicit — is that "Israel is not subject to a constellation" means that by great merit one's fortune is changed. And so it is proved from our own passage, for Rava asked for Rav Huna's wisdom and Rav Chisda's wealth, which are matters fixed by the decree at birth, since the angel sets up the drop and asks whether it shall be wise or foolish, rich or poor; perforce one must say that by an abundance of pleading for mercy from Heaven, as Rava did, the decree and the constellation under which a man was born can be annulled. **Maharal (Derech Chaim 4:9):** If we see one who is not a wholly righteous man, and he is a poor Torah scholar, this too has its cause: his ill fortune brings it about, for "life, children and sustenance do not depend upon merit." And even of a wholly righteous man one may say the same, that his ill fortune is the cause — as we find with R. Elazar ben Pedat in Taanit, whose fortune was so exceedingly bad that he had no sustenance at all. **Rav Tzadok (Dover Tzedek, Miscellany 4:98):** Although children, life and sustenance "do not depend on merit but on mazal" — one's hidden root — the whole Torah is full of reward and punishment in these three, for through merit the mazal changes, as one's deeds incline the hidden root. Yet sometimes both men are completely righteous, as with Rabbah and R. Chisda — which Rosh Hashanah attributes to Rabbah's descent from the house of Eli — and in truth this is what is called mazal: a hidden root drawn from one's forebears, though he himself did nothing. Effort still helped, but because of his mazal Rabbah needed more effort, while less sufficed for R. Chisda. **Rav Tzadok (Likutei Ma'amarim, festival discourses 16):** Children, life and sustenance comprise all of a person's needs in this world, where there is no reward for a commandment, and so they are decreed at the beginning of formation — "wise or foolish, strong or weak, rich or poor" — whereas "righteous or wicked," which is merit, is not. Yet the Torah promises all three as reward, for insofar as they bear on Torah and the commandments — long life to multiply Torah, children to serve God, a ready livelihood — they certainly depend on merit, which can change the mazal; what depends on mazal, decreed at formation, is given even where it does not aid the service of God. **Rav Tzadok (Machshavos Charutz 15):** Children, life and sustenance, which "do not depend on merit but on mazal," cannot be attained through prayer; hence they said that sustenance and matching a couple are as hard as the splitting of the Sea. Although we petition for sustenance in every prayer, that is for one born in an hour of sustenance or who prays at a time of favor; but for one not so born, like R. Elazar ben Pedas, it depends on the supernal mazal in Atika, and prayer no longer avails — only Torah and calling to Him in truth, which is above mazal. **Rav Tzadok (Pri Tzaddik, Balak 6):** The root of all blessings is life, children and sustenance, which "do not depend on merit but on mazal"; the Zohar teaches that this is the attribute of Atika, which is "upon the Lord," as in "Hannah prayed upon the Lord" and "cast your burden upon the Lord" — the tip of the yod above the letters of the Name, alluding to Ayin [Nothingness]. When one merits the primordial light, the dew of Atika, one merits these three. **Rav Tzadok (Takanas HaShavin 1):** The souls of converts too were at Mount Sinai, as the Sages said, "their mazal was there" — and mazal is a person's root, as I have written elsewhere on "a person has a mazal" and on children, life and sustenance, which "depend on mazal." **Beis Yaakov (Vayechi 45):** Of sustenance the Sages said that it "does not depend on merit" — that is, not on the service a person performs with knowledge and clarity when his mind is clear and settled — "but on mazal": holiness must be engraved in his heart so permanently that it does not budge even when his knowledge and clarity are diminished. This is called mazal because service flows from him of itself, even without his awareness; sustenance must be drawn from a place above merit, from the supernal will called mazal.

for these three necessities. (:²קדושין לט"ז) "שכר מצוה בהאי עולמא ליכא" — **And even though "there is no reward for a mitzvah in this world" (Kiddushin 39b),** — **signifying that "around Him it storms exceedingly,"** — **so that retribution is exacted in this world while reward is preserved for the World to Come, as is known;** — **nevertheless, it proceeds through strict justice according to merit.** — **Furthermore, our Sages of blessed memory stated**

² **Kiddushin 39b** — Rava said: Whose opinion is this? It is R. Yaakov's, who says: There is no reward for a commandment in this world. As it is taught: R. Yaakov says: There is not a single commandment written in the Torah whose reward is stated alongside it that is not dependent upon the resurrection of the dead. A man's father said to him, Climb the tower and fetch me fledglings; he climbed the tower, sent away the mother and took the young, and on his way back he fell and died. Where is the goodness of this one's days, and where is the length of this one's days? Rather, "that it may go well with you" — in the world that is wholly good; "that your days may be long" — in the world that is wholly long. **Rashi (s.v. "that is not dependent upon the resurrection of the dead"):** The reward stated alongside the commandment is not paid out here at all; it is stated in this way to make known to you that there is no giving of reward except in the world to come. **Tosafos (s.v. "the mishna refers to a case where they make him a good day and a bad day"):** Rashi's reading is difficult, for Rava's "Whose opinion is this? R. Yaakov's" implies that until now the mishna had not been established according to R. Yaakov, whereas on Rashi's explanation Abaye too had established both the mishna and the baraita according to him. Rabbeinu Tam therefore explains that both the good day and the bad day are in this world — sometimes a good day is made for the wicked man so that he may receive the reward of his commandments here, and a bad day for the righteous man so that his sins may be scourged away here — and this is not like R. Yaakov, who holds that there is no reward for a commandment in this world at all. **Maharsha:** Do not object from all the promises of the Torah, which can only be understood of this world. R. Yaakov concedes that the merit of the community and its good deeds bring upon it in this world too all the blessings and good things named in the Torah, and the reverse for the community's sin; he spoke only of the individual, whose reward, when his merits are many, is wholly in the world to come, since here evil is done to him in order to give him merit there — and conversely one whose sins are many is given good here in order to drive him from the world to come. **Maharal (Chiddushei Aggados, Kiddushin 39b):** Because the reward that belongs to the commandments is so great, their reward is not in this world; and one cannot say that He pays part of the reward of a commandment in this world and part in the world to come, for there is no payment by halves — hence there is no reward for a commandment in this world. R. Yaakov concedes that a wicked man does receive payment for a commandment he performed, since his reward is not so great; and because it is not great it can be discharged here, for a great reward cannot be given in this world, as they said, "one hour of contentment in the world to come is better than all the life of this world." **Rav Tzadok (Divrei Soferim 25):** Every commandment has its own reward, in the world to come and also in this world through its fruits: only the reward of the commandment itself "is not in this world," but a reward of fruits exists for every commandment, each in its own way — like "tithe so that you become rich," or children for sending away the mother bird. The Mishnah's "things whose fruits a person eats [in this world]" means only that for these one is assured of eating the fruits here, whereas for other commandments the fruits too may remain for the world to come. **Rav Tzadok (Dover Tzedek, Kuntres Dover Tzedek, Eruvin 4):** Sins have a limit, as this world has a limit, but the commandments have none; therefore "there is no reward for a commandment in this world," since this world is bounded and the reward of the commandments has no bound. **Rav Tzadok (Likutei Ma'amaram, festival discourses 7):** The world to come is the cessation of activity, where the righteous enjoy the radiance of the Presence, and Shabbos is a taste of it; though "there is no reward for a commandment in this world," it is for this reason that Shabbos is called a "good gift." **Rav Tzadok (Pri Tzaddik, Chanukah 13):** Life does not depend on merit but on mazal because "there is no reward for commandments in this world"; but that is only the reward of a commandment done out of obligation, whereas what one does beyond the letter of the law the Holy One, blessed be He, repays in one's lifetime. That is why [the Gemara] lists acts of piety as the cause of long life. **Rav Tzadok (Tzidkas HaTzaddik 171):** "There is no reward for a commandment in this world" because the Holy One, blessed be He, gives a full load, and this world cannot receive that abundance of good at all; so here only sins are repaid, unless one merits tasting the fruit of his deeds or of commandments that bear fruit. Hence a time, place or soul "prepared for calamity" [pur'aniyos] is prepared for repayment [pera'on]: there the abundance of the repayment becomes calamity, as in the breaking of the vessels through excess of light. **Beis Yaakov (Vayeitzei 6):** Because "there is no reward for a commandment in this world," Israel holds only the markers [tziyunim] of the good, while the essence of the good is with the nations; in the future both will be joined together with Israel, as the Blessed One returns the essence to the place of the markers — hence the blessing "Who returns His Presence to Zion [Tziyon]."

³ **Shabbat 156a** — It was stated: R. Chanina says — there is a constellation that makes one wise and a constellation that makes one rich, and there is a constellation for Israel. R. Yochanan said: There is no constellation governing Israel. And R. Yochanan follows his own reasoning, for R. Yochanan said: From where do we know that there is no constellation governing Israel? For it is said, "Thus says the Lord: Learn not the way of the nations, and be not dismayed at the signs of heaven, for the nations are dismayed at them" — the nations are dismayed, but not Israel. **Rashi:** "A constellation makes one wise" — wisdom accords with the constellation, as it said [above] that one born under the sun will be bright

(Shabbat 156a): "There is no mazal for Israel," עין שם — and this was raised as a difficulty by the Tosafot, see there. יודעים — However, in truth this mazal does not refer to the celestial constellations known to astrologers, ⁴שעל זה אמרו (שם) — concerning which they said (there) that "there is no mazal, etc.," negating astrological influence, כפי בשרון נפשותם, — for with the children of Israel everything is governed by supernal divine judgment according to the fitness of their souls. — Rather, this mazal is

and wise; "and there is a constellation for Israel" — for prayer and charity do not change the constellation. "There is no constellation governing Israel" — for through prayer and merit one's constellation is changed for the better. **Tosafos (s.v. "there is no constellation governing Israel"):** As for Rava's statement at the end of Moed Katan (28a), that children, life and sustenance depend not on merit but on the constellation: [the constellation] is nonetheless changed through great merit, though at times it is not changed; as it says in Yevamot, chapter HaCholetz (50a), "If he merits, they add to him; if he does not merit, they reduce for him." **Maharsha:** Tosafot wrote that through great merit [the constellation] is changed; but then, according to R. Chanina, who says there is a constellation for Israel, even great merit would not change it — yet all the Torah's promises, the blessings "if you hearken" and the curses "if you do not hearken," imply no such thing, but make [Israel's lot] depend on their merit or guilt. One may answer that the Torah's promises were said of the community of Israel, and the merit of the many certainly does not depend on the constellation at all; they dispute here only concerning the individual, R. Chanina holding that a constellation makes that individual wise or rich, and R. Yochanan that there is no constellation for Israel even for an individual — for he expounds "the nations are dismayed," but not Israel, even a single Israelite. **Maharal (Chiddushei Aggados, Shabbos 156a):** [R. Yochanan] means that the constellation can be outweighed through mitzvos, even without any prayer — for that prayer avails is obvious, since the Blessed One does as He wishes in heaven and on earth. The community of Israel has in itself a supernal, separate level, as does the individual when he performs a divine mitzvah, and this stands above the constellation. This does not mean that the constellation has no hold on them at all — when it stands strongly against Israel they need great merit to outweigh it, as in Egypt, where it portended evil and the Blessed Name turned it to good for the merit of the forefathers — but that they are not wholly under the constellation as the other nations are.

⁴ **Shabbat 156a** — It was stated: R. Chanina says: A constellation makes one wise, a constellation makes one wealthy, and Israel is subject to a constellation. R. Yochanan says: Israel is not subject to a constellation. And R. Yochanan follows his own reasoning, for R. Yochanan said: From where do we know that Israel is not subject to a constellation? As it is stated, "Thus said the Lord: Do not learn the way of the nations, and do not be dismayed by the signs of heaven, for the nations are dismayed by them" — they are dismayed, but Israel is not. **Rashi:** "A constellation makes one wise" — wisdom accords with the constellation, as it said [above] that one born under the sun will be bright and wise; "and there is a constellation for Israel" — for prayer and charity do not change the constellation. "There is no constellation governing Israel" — for through prayer and merit one's constellation is changed for the better. **Tosafos (s.v. "there is no constellation governing Israel"):** As for Rava's statement at the end of Moed Katan (28a), that children, life and sustenance depend not on merit but on the constellation: [the constellation] is nonetheless changed through great merit, though at times it is not changed; as it says in Yevamot, chapter HaCholetz (50a), "If he merits, they add to him; if he does not merit, they reduce for him." **Maharsha:** Tosafot wrote that through great merit [the constellation] is changed; but then, according to R. Chanina, who says there is a constellation for Israel, even great merit would not change it — yet all the Torah's promises, the blessings "if you hearken" and the curses "if you do not hearken," imply no such thing, but make [Israel's lot] depend on their merit or guilt. One may answer that the Torah's promises were said of the community of Israel, and the merit of the many certainly does not depend on the constellation at all; they dispute here only concerning the individual, R. Chanina holding that a constellation makes that individual wise or rich, and R. Yochanan that there is no constellation for Israel even for an individual — for he expounds "the nations are dismayed," but not Israel, even a single Israelite. **Maharal (Chiddushei Aggados, Shabbos 156a):** [R. Yochanan] means that the constellation can be outweighed through mitzvos, even without any prayer — for that prayer avails is obvious, since the Blessed One does as He wishes in heaven and on earth. The community of Israel has in itself a supernal, separate level, as does the individual when he performs a divine mitzvah, and this stands above the constellation. This does not mean that the constellation has no hold on them at all — when it stands strongly against Israel they need great merit to outweigh it, as in Egypt, where it portended evil and the Blessed Name turned it to good for the merit of the forefathers — but that they are not wholly under the constellation as the other nations are.

⁵ **Shabbat 53b** — And is there such a thing as an amulet proven effective for a person and not proven effective for an animal? Yes: a person, who has a mazal, is aided by it; an animal, which has no mazal, is not aided by it. **Rashi:** "Mazal": his angel, who intercedes on his behalf. **Maharsha (Chiddushei Halachos):** This implies that an amulet proven for an animal is all the more effective for a person, who has a mazal; but then the Gemara's next question — "if so, what is 'this is a stringency with an animal'?" — is difficult, for that would itself be a stringency with an animal. He suggests, with some strain, that the Talmud takes it as settled that an amulet proven for an animal is likewise not thereby proven for a person. **Rav Tzadok (Dover Tzedek, Miscellany 4:90):** "A person has a mazal," which Rashi explains as the interceding angel, means his hidden root, from which he is wholly drawn; on it depend children, life and sustenance, the three

what they stated at the beginning of Bava Kamma (2b) and in Shabbat (53b): "אדם דאית ליה מזל" — "a human being who possesses a mazal," — which Rashi explained: a guardian, advocating angel (malach meilitz). וְהָיָה זֶה וְדָא מַצַּד הַזִּכּוּת, — Now, this advocacy certainly stems from merit, וְכִמְדֵּי שְׂאֵמְרוּ בְּשִׁבְתָּ (לב).) על פְּסוּקִים "אם נש עָלָיו מְלָאךְ מְלִיץ וגוֹמֵר, — as they expounded in Shabbat (32a) on the verse: "If there be for him an advocating angel, etc.,," — והוא פָּשוּט גַּם כֵּן, כִּי אֵין מְלִיצָה וְלִמּוּד סְגוּרָא, — and this is also straightforward, for there is no defense advocacy except when undergoing judgment. וְאִמְנָם שׁוֹרֵשׁ עֲנִין מְלָאךְ מְלִיץ שֶׁיֵּשׁ לְכָל אֶחָד מִיִּשְׂרָאֵל, — Yet the primal root of this advocating angel belonging to each member of Israel, וְאִמְנָם שׁוֹרֵשׁ עֲנִין מְלָאךְ מְלִיץ שֶׁיֵּשׁ לְכָל אֶחָד מִיִּשְׂרָאֵל, — even unto a day-old infant, as proven from the opening of Bava Kamma, אִם כֵּן עַל פְּרָחֶךָ אֵינוֹ מְלָאךְ הַנוֹצֵר, — perforce cannot be an angel created via the performance of mitzvot. עַל יְדֵי עֲשִׂיַת הַמִּצְוֹת רַק דְּעָצָם נִפְּשׁ, — Rather, man's essential soul, being hewn from the Throne of Glory which transcends the angelic realm, הָיָה יֵשׁ בּוֹ מִכָּל הָעוֹלָמוֹת שֶׁתַּתְּהִי, — contains elements from all the worlds situated beneath it; וְכִדְּשָׁאֲמָרוּ זְכֵרֵנָם לְבִרְכָּה (חֲגִיגָה יג.), — for as is known, every higher world encompasses all that lies beneath it, וְשֶׁהָרִי מִמֶּנּוּ הוּא מִתְפַּשֵּׁט וְיוֹצֵא, — since from it lower reality expands and emanates. — And as our Sages of blessed memory stated (Chagigah 13a): "רַגְלֵי הַחַיּוֹת כְּנֶגֶד כְּלֹן, קֶרְסֵלִי וְכוּלִי," — "the feet of the Chayyot

general powers of the soul, and not on merit and deeds — so the main task is to rectify the root until it cleaves to the Lord even in its hidden aspects. *Rav Tzadok (Takanas HaShavin 1)*: The souls of converts too were at Mount Sinai, as the Sages said, "their mazal was there" — and mazal is a person's root, as I have written elsewhere on "a person has a mazal" and on children, life and sustenance, which "depend on mazal."

⁶ **Bava Kamma 2b** — Why is it written of a person "if it gores" (Exodus 21:28), and of an animal "if it hurts" (Exodus 21:35)? A person, who has fortune — of him it is written "if it gores"; an animal, which has no fortune — of it is written "if it hurts." *Rashi*: "A person, who has fortune" — who has the sense to guard his own body. "Of him it is written 'if it gores'" — because the ox certainly intended to do harm and came at him with force, whereas "hurts" would imply only that it found him standing and shoved him with its horns. Another reading: because he has fortune he is not easily killed by a shove, which is only a slight thrust of the horn, but only by goring — with force, with intent, and with the horn driven into the body. *Rav Tzadok (Pri Tzaddik, Bo 2)*: So we find: "A person, who has a mazal — 'if it gores' is written; an animal, which has no mazal — 'if it strikes [yigof]' is written," meaning a mere blow to the body, since, as Rashi there explains, the word derives from guf, "body." Hence the [first] seven plagues, whose purpose was to bring out from the seven lower [attributes] of the husk, which have the form of a body, are called "all My plagues [magefotai]," a term of "body," for through them the holy body of Israel was drawn out of the impure body of Egypt.

⁷ **Shabbat 32a** — A man should never stand in a place of danger and say that a miracle will be performed for him — lest no miracle be performed for him; and if a miracle is performed for him, it is deducted from his merits. *Rashi*: "Deducted": that is, diminished. *Maharal (Chiddushei Aggados, Shabbos 32a)*: When a miracle is performed for a man he goes out of the natural order, and so it is deducted from his merits, which are not natural at all but are kept for him for the World to Come, which is above nature. When the Blessed One deals with a man above nature and performs a miracle for him, He deducts it from those merits, for the man is then consuming in this world what was due to him in the World to Come.

⁸ **Chagigah 13a** — Above them are the holy creatures. The feet of the creatures are equal to all of them [the firmaments together]; the ankles of the creatures are equal to all of them; the shins of the creatures are equal to all of them; and so the knees, the thighs, the bodies, the necks, the heads, and the horns of the creatures — each is equal to all of them. Above them is the Throne of Glory: the feet of the Throne of Glory are equal to all of them, and the Throne of Glory is equal to all of them; and the King, the living and enduring God, high and exalted, dwells above them. *Rashi*: "The feet of the creatures" — the thickness of their hooves; the ankles are the joints above them; the shin is the bone sold together with the foot; the knee is the thigh bone adjoining the shin; and the thigh is the hip bone set into the loins. *Tosafos (s.v. "and the feet of the creatures are equal to all of them")*: Some emend the Kedushah composed by the Kalir — "and the creatures, foursquare beneath the Throne, the sole of a foot, five hundred and fifteen" — striking out the "and," since by the reckoning here the seven firmaments and the eight spaces between them come to fifteen times five hundred. But they struck it out needlessly, for the Kalir framed his words after the Jerusalem Talmud, where a single foot is said to be greater still; and it was his way in many places to leave the reckoning of our Talmud in order to hold to that of the Jerusalem Talmud. *Maharsha*: The eight spaces must be counted thus: one from the earth to the firmament, then seven firmaments with six spaces between them, which is fourteen, and the sole of the foot, five hundred, counted as a fifteenth — fifteen times five hundred in all. But since our passage says that the feet of the creatures are equal to all of them, meaning to all the five hundreds already counted, the sole of the foot cannot be the same as "the feet of the creatures." And "the horns of the creatures" spoken of here must be the horns of the ox of the Chariot, since horns do not apply to the others.

equal all of them, the ankles, etc.," and likewise whatever is above outweighs all that is beneath it. שְׁאֵמֵר "נַעֲשֶׂה אָדָם", שְׁאֵמֵר — וְכִאֲמָרָם זְכָרֹנָם לְבִרְכָּהּ (סְנֵהֲדִין ל"ח):⁹ מֶה שְׁאֵמֵר "נַעֲשֶׂה אָדָם", שְׁאֵמֵר — And as they stated (Sanhedrin 38b): when Hashem said "Let us make man," He addressed the angels; וְכִינֵן שֶׁהַקֹּדֶשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא אָמַר לָהֶם "נַעֲשֶׂה", — and since the Holy One, blessed be He, said to them "Let us make," שֶׁזֶּה לְמוֹד דֶּרֶךְ אֶרֶץ לְמַלְךְ¹⁰ — וְכִינֵן שֶׁהַקֹּדֶשׁ בְּרוּךְ הוּא אָמַר לָהֶם "נַעֲשֶׂה", — even though our Sages expounded (Bereishit Rabbah 8) that this teaches proper conduct to consult others, etc., — וְנִדָּא לֹא נִכְתָּב דְּבַר שֶׁקֶר, — Scripture certainly did not record a falsehood; רק שֶׁהִרְוָה, — only that one wishing to err may err, thinking that the statement implies He required their partnership, וְכִינֵן שֶׁזֶּה אֵלָּא לְמוֹד דֶּרֶךְ אֶרֶץ, — whereas in truth it is simply a lesson in humility and derech eretz, עַל יְדֵי זֶה מִמִּילָא, — אָבֵל בְּאֵמֶת, אִמִּית הַשֵּׁם וְתִבְרַךְ "נַעֲשֶׂה אָדָם", — Yet in absolute truth, Hashem's utterance "Let us make man" spontaneously instilled within him potency from all the worlds; וְזֶהוּ עֵקֶר "בְּצַלְמֵנו", שֶׁהוּא כּוֹלֵל כָּל הָעוֹלָמוֹת בְּכִדּוּשׁ, — and this is the primary meaning of "in our image"—encompassing all cosmic realms, as is known. וְהִצָּר הָרַע, — And the evil inclination stems from this physical world wherein merit and culpability apply; — אָבֵל בְּמַלְאָכִים אֵין יֵצֵר הָרַע, כִּמוֹ שְׁאֵמֵרוֹ זְכָרֹנָם לְבִרְכָּהּ (שְׁבִת פט¹²); — whereas

⁹ **Sanhedrin 38b** — Rav Yehuda said in the name of Rav: When the Holy One, blessed be He, wished to create man, He created one company of ministering angels. He said to them: Is it your will that we make man in our image? They said before Him: Master of the Universe, what are his deeds? He said to them: Such and such are his deeds. They said before Him: "What is man that You are mindful of him, and the son of man that You think of him?" He stretched out His little finger among them and burned them. **Maharsha:** This is explained by what the Midrash Rabbah says: when the Holy One, blessed be He, came to create man, the angels divided into factions — Kindness said, "Let him be created, for he performs acts of kindness"; Truth said, "Let him not be created, for he is all falsehood"; Righteousness said, "Let him be created, for he does righteous deeds"; Peace said, "Let him not be created, for he is all strife" — and the two factions here are those of Truth and of Peace. "Such and such are his deeds" means acts of kindness and righteousness, and they answered, "What is man [enosh]" — he is all falsehood, like the idolatrous generation of Enosh — "and the son of man [ben adam]" — he is all strife, like Cain, who quarreled with his brother Abel and killed him. His "finger" is the attribute with which He created the world ("Your heavens, the work of Your fingers"), namely kindness, as it is said, "the world is built by kindness"; with it He "burned" the factions, that is, He prevailed over them with the attribute of kindness to create the world — and kindness is the third faction, which consented to the world's creation. **Maharal (Chiddushei Agados, Sanhedrin 38b):** The first and second factions depart from the balanced middle and so lack the simplicity of the Holy One, blessed be He, and are not close to Him; they therefore accused man, since from the side of the wicked man does not merit to be created — hence "What is man that You are mindful of him?" "He stretched out His little finger among them and burned them": when the Holy One, blessed be He, wishes to annul a creation He does it with the slightest thing, a small touch — merely touching and drawing near to them burns them — as in "he did not touch me even with his little finger" (Shabbat 13a); for whatever has come into being, even a being separate from matter, is subject to annulment. Alternatively, the little finger stands for man, the smallest beside the angels on high: as a hand without its little finger is lacking, so the world is incomplete without man, and therefore it was the little finger that opposed them and burned them.

¹⁰ **Bereishit Rabbah 8:8** — R. Shmuel bar Nachman said in the name of R. Yonatan: When Moses was writing the Torah, he would write the work of each day; when he reached this verse, "And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness," he said before Him: Master of the worlds, why do You give an opening to the heretics? He said to him: Write, and whoever wishes to err will err. The Holy One, blessed be He, said to Moses, this man whom I have created — do I not raise up from him both great and small? Should a great man come to take permission from one smaller than himself and say, Why must I take permission from one smaller than I? — they will say to him, Learn from your Creator, who created the upper and the lower worlds, and yet when He came to create man He took counsel with the ministering angels.

¹¹ **Rashi, Genesis 1:26** — Even though they did not assist Him in forming man, and there is here an opening for the heretics to assert their claim, Scripture did not refrain from writing it — to teach the way of courtesy and the trait of humility: that the greater should consult and take permission from the lesser.

¹² **Shabbat 89a** — [Moses said to the ministering angels:] Again, what is written in it? "Honor your father and your mother" — do you have a father and a mother? Again, what is written in it? "You shall not murder," "You shall not commit adultery," "You shall not steal" — is there jealousy among you? Is there an evil inclination among you? At once they conceded to the Holy One, blessed be He. **Rashi:** "Is there jealousy among you?" — through which you would come to murder. **Maharsha:** Once it had been shown that even the hidden part of the Torah is within man's reach, through the soul that is bound to the Throne of Glory, Moshe argued that the Torah should be given to him rather than set in heaven, on account of its revealed part — "what is written in it?" Therefore "at once the ministering angels conceded" that it is more fitting to give the Torah to Israel than to set its glory and secret in heaven, since the revealed

among angels there is no evil inclination, as our Sages stated (Shabbat 89a), אָבֵל מִכָּל מְקוֹם יֵשׁ לָהֶם, – yet they nevertheless engage in spiritual exertion, which is the chanting of celestial song. – אָבֵל מֵה שְׁלֹמֶעֱלָה מֵהֶם, גם זֶה אֵין שִׁינְךָ. – However, in the realm above them, even exertion is inapplicable, – "בְּרִכּוֹת יוֹשִׁיבִים וְכוּלֵי נִגְהָנִים וְכוּלֵי",¹³ – there being only the reception of divine radiance, as in: "the righteous sit crowned, delighting, etc." (Berakhot 17a) שְׁמֵהוּ, וּמִצַּד שִׁרְשׁוֹ. – which represents the root of man's soul in the ultimate heights. שׁוֹרֵשׁ נִפְשׁ הָאָדָם לְמַעְלָה מֵמַעְלָה. – And from the perspective of its root in the angelic realm, that root is the advocating angel—namely the spiritual power of his own soul; וְלִכְן נִקְרָא, "מַזְלָא", – therefore it is termed "mazal," representing the soul's

Torah has no application in heaven. **Maharal (*Derush al HaTorah* 5):** Moshe answered each of the first five commandments separately but the later ones in a single reply, because the first five are between man and God — "Honor your father and your mother" among them, for there are three partners in a person, and one who honors his parents is accounted as having honored the Holy One, blessed be He — while the last five are all between man and his fellow. These are joined together, since a sin against people leaves its mark on the one sinned against, whereas of a sin against Heaven it is said, "If you have sinned, what do you effect against Him?" **Maharal (*Tiferes Yisrael*, ch. 24):** Moshe's "what is written in it?" means that although the angels grasp of themselves that there is an order ordained by the Blessed One, the order itself belongs to man alone: the Torah, though created before the world, is arranged according to man's humanity — its commandments correspond to his 248 limbs — and, like the Divine image, which needs a physical body to bear it, it rests upon physical things, the practical commandments, and requires a physical bearer. That was the answer to the angels, and therefore "they conceded."

13 Berakhot 17a — Rav was wont to say: The World to Come is not like this world. In the World to Come there is no eating and no drinking, no procreation and no commerce, no envy and no hatred and no rivalry. Rather, the righteous sit with their crowns upon their heads and take delight in the radiance of the Divine Presence, as it is stated: "And they beheld God, and they ate and drank" (Exodus 24:11). **Rashi**: "And they ate and drank" — they were sated by the radiance of the Divine Presence as though they had eaten and drunk. **Maharsha**: He derives the point from the redundancy and the change of wording in the verse: Scripture had already said "and they saw the God of Israel," and then says again "and they beheld God" — and "beholding" generally denotes an intellectual vision, a prophecy. They beheld and took delight in the radiance of the Divine Presence as though they had eaten and drunk; for at the giving of the Torah they were in the likeness of the World to Come, their crowns upon their heads, as it is said [in Shabbat 88a] that every Israelite received two crowns, and they were removed from bodily things, as it is said of Moses that he did not eat for forty days. **Maharal (Derech Chaim on Avot 3:16)**: The meaning is that in the World to Come a man needs no completing, unlike this world, in which a man must receive his completion; there he will be complete on a higher level. He will therefore need no eating and drinking to complete himself, nor procreation — for offspring are a man's completion — nor commerce, by which a man supplies what he lacks; and there will be no envy or hatred, since these are themselves a defect. And "the righteous sit": the World to Come is not a thing of motion as this world is, and sitting signifies that a man is already complete in actuality and no longer moving toward his completion. **Rav Tzadok (Divrei Soferim 4)**: Seeking to be a son of the World to Come purely for one's own sake is no different from seeking a reward in this world; but the essence of the World to Come, that "they delight in the radiance of the Shechinah," is not self-benefit. One can merit this even in this world — the "one hour of repentance and good deeds in this world" that is better than all the World to Come — when the reward of a mitzvah brings one to repentance, love and cleaving; for such a reward one may hope, and serving for it is wholly for its own sake, out of love. **Rav Tzadok (Likutei Ma'amaram, festival discourses 7)**: Shabbat is one-sixtieth of the World to Come, and the World to Come is the absence of the action of "today to do them" — only "the righteous [sit] ... and delight in the radiance of the Shechinah" — and Shabbat holds a semblance of this, which is why, though there is no reward for mitzvos in this world, Shabbat is called "a good gift." In this world one employs the powers of action, whereas the World to Come is the heart alone. **Rav Tzadok (Machshavos Charutz 11)**: From within this world, which is likened to night, they will merit the light of the World to Come, which is wholly day with no darkness or evil — the light of the world of Atzilus, the light of the seven days of creation hidden away for the righteous — when they sit "with their crowns on their heads," that is, their attachment to their root in the Blessed One, "and delight in the radiance of the Shechinah," that is, the upper Shechinah. This is the first heh of the Name, alluding to the understanding in the heart, the secret of the World to Come, where the attachment of the hearts of Israel to their source is revealed. **Tiferes Yosef (Rosh Hashanah 1)**: With the creation of man "tohu and bohu" were set aside, for a person can raise his actions without limit and reach a lofty place, as stated: "In the World to Come there is no eating and no drinking ... rather the righteous sit with their crowns on their heads and delight in the radiance of the Shechinah." Through the act of the mitzvah of shofar one arouses the "great shofar," which shows that Israel raise all their actions up to the "upper sun," to the place where the righteous sit with their crowns on their heads and delight in the radiance of the Shechinah, and through the shofar one can reach with one's actions and service to the light of the Infinite.

root allotted to his portion at birth, "שעל זה אמרו (נדה טז):¹⁴ "טפה זו מה תהא עליה וכולי, **which they taught (Niddah 16b): "This drop, what shall become of it, etc.,"** רצה לומר: איזה נפש יושפע – **And as written in Shemot Rabbah (Parashah 40), – that all souls derive from the stature of Adam the First:** "ש. בראשו ויש ברגלו – **some stem from his head and some from his foot,** ומליצת המלאך, לפי שעל ידי העברות. – **and each possesses a designated spiritual power.** וילקל אחד פת מיוחד ומליצת המלאך, לפי שעל ידי העברות. – **And the angel's advocacy functions because through sins "they weaken the power of the Heavenly Host" (Eichah Rabbah 1:6);** ואף דשם בעולם – **and even though in the angelic world there is no intrinsic merit or guilt,** מכל – **nevertheless, corresponding to merit and**

¹⁴ **Niddah 16b** — R. Chanina bar Pappa expounded: The angel appointed over conception is named Night. He takes the drop and sets it before the Holy One, blessed be He, and says before Him: Master of the Universe, what shall become of this drop? Mighty or weak? Wise or foolish? Rich or poor? **Rashi:** "Everything is in the hands of Heaven" — all a man's qualities and all that befalls him come upon him by the decree of the King, except this one. "But to fear" — this alone He asks of you, because everything else is in His hand and this is in yours. **Tosafos (s.v. "the angel appointed over conception"):** But over birth no angel is appointed, as is said at the beginning of Ta'anit: three keys are in the hand of the Holy One, blessed be He — of a woman in childbirth, of rain, and of the resurrection of the dead. Even those three keys are at times handed over to an agent for a time, for Elijah held the key of rain and revived the dead, and so did Elisha and many righteous men; and even Beri, who is the prince of rain, acts only by the permission of the Holy One, blessed be He. **Tosafos (s.v. "everything is in the hands of Heaven except the fear of Heaven"):** In "Elu Na'arot" it is said that everything is in the hands of Heaven except cold and heat. Here the statement concerns a man's nature and his traits, while there it concerns the things that befall him, such as illnesses and calamities, all of which are decreed upon him and against which he cannot guard himself — except cold and heat, against which he can guard himself. **Maharsha (Chidushei Agadot, s.v. "this drop, what shall become of it — mighty or weak, wise [or foolish]"):** This is the meaning of the verse "Let not the wise man glory in his wisdom": what is compelled is neither praised nor blamed, and therefore these three — wisdom, might and wealth — which are compelled by the decree from the hour of a man's formation, are no ground for glorying. "But let him that glories glory in this, that he understands and knows Me" — for that is the thing which depends upon his choice. **Maharal (Chidushei Agadot, Niddah 16b):** He is called Night because the gestation takes place in the woman's belly, "like the bones in the womb of her that is with child," and the child is there in darkness. Therefore the angel appointed over gestation is called Night, since in the belly it is always night and never day. **Rav Tzadok (Likutei Ma'amaram, festival discourses 16):** The Sages said that "children, life and sustenance depend not on merit but on mazal," for these three comprise all of a man's needs in this world, and this is decreed at the beginning of his formation: "wise or foolish" — and "wisdom gives life to those who possess it," so from it life is drawn; "mighty or weak" — from this come children, "like arrows in the hand of a mighty man, so are the children of youth"; "rich or poor" is the flow of sustenance. But "righteous or wicked," which is a matter of merit, he did not say.

¹⁵ **Shemot Rabbah 40:3** — While Adam the first man still lay a shapeless mass, the Holy One, blessed be He, showed him every righteous man destined to arise from him: one is suspended from Adam's head, one from his hair, one from his forehead, one from his eyes, one from his nose, one from his mouth, one from his ear, one from his earlobe. Know this: when Job sought to argue with the Holy One, blessed be He, He answered him, "Where [eifo] were you when I founded the earth?" R. Shimon ben Lakish said: The Holy One, blessed be He, said to him — Job, tell Me from what place your measure [eifah] was suspended, from his head or from his forehead or from which of his limbs; if you know where your measure was, you may argue with Me.

¹⁶ **Eichah Rabbah 1:33** — R. Yehuda son of R. Simon said in the name of R. Levi son of R. Tarfon: When Israel do the will of the Holy One, blessed be He, they add strength to the might above, as it says, "And now, let the power of the Lord be great"; and when they do not do the will of the Holy One, blessed be He, they, as it were, weaken the great power above — and they themselves also go "without strength before the pursuer." **Rav Tzadok (Likutei Ma'amaram, on completing the Talmud 5):** A deficiency can touch the mind only through its link below to the heart, when it turns downward and not to its cause, for the arousal from below begets the arousal from above, and likewise the desire in the heart begets the thought in the mind; and this is [the meaning of] "You weakened the Rock that bore you," that they weaken the power of the heavenly household. **Rav Tzadok (Machshavos Charutz 19):** By all opinions, addition of strength and weakening of strength certainly apply to the angels as well, as the Sages said on the verse "You weakened the Rock that bore you" that they weaken the power of the heavenly household, and on "Ascribe strength to God" that they add strength to the heavenly household. So Abraham our father, through his meal and the commandment of hospitality, added strength to the heavenly household and "sustained their hearts." **Rav Tzadok (Pri Tzaddik, Kedushas HaShabbos 2):** All the supernal forces of holiness depend on man, as it is said on "You weakened the Rock that bore you" that they weaken the power of the heavenly household, and at the Destruction the wings of the Chayos and the heavenly household were diminished: for they too are part of the whole creation, which is all for the sake of man, the likeness upon the Throne who rides upon all of creation.

guilt below, so is the power of the angels' song and striving, רָצָה לוֹמַר מִצַּד שֶׁהֵם עֲצֵם שׁוֹרֵשׁ לְנַפְשׁוֹת דִּישָׁרָאֵל, – meaning because they are the essential celestial root for the souls of Israel. וכֵּן הַמְּלִיצָה הוּא כְּפִי כֹחַ – And the potency of advocacy corresponds directly to the force of one's actions, – המְעִשִׁים כִּי אֵין בְּחִירָה, – for there is no independent free choice in angels to elect to advocate and speak thus; רַק שֶׁהוּא מְמִילָא, – rather it occurs automatically, – הָרִי כֹחַ הַמְּלִיצָה, – שֶׁשֶּׁשְׂאֵדָם וְכֹאִי, – שָׁבוּ לַמַּעֲלָה בְּעוֹלָם הַמְּלִיצָה הוּא מְלִיצָה מְלִיץ וְשׁוֹרֵשׁ נִשְׁמָתוֹ בְּעוֹלָם הַכֶּסֶם מְקַבֵּל אוֹרָה כְּרָאוּי. – And the root of his soul in the World of the Throne receives its divine illumination to channel downward unto Ruach and Nefesh, – (יוֹמָא לט.): "מְקַדְשִׁין אוֹתוֹ מִלְּמַעְלָה, – וְנִמְצָא כְּפִי זֶה: הַכֹּל תְּלוּי בְּנוֹכְחָא. – Thus according to this perspective, everything depends entirely on merit, – וְזֶהוּ מִצַּד הַבְּחִירָה דְּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה, – וְנִמְצָא כְּפִי זֶה: הַכֹּל תְּלוּי בְּנוֹכְחָא, – [and this reflects the vantage point of free choice in this world,] [while from the vantage point of ultimate Divine Foreknowledge, everything depends on mazal, and in truth all is one], – וְאִמָּנָם עִם כָּל זֶה, בְּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה יֵשׁ רָשָׁעִים שֶׁמַּגִּיעַ אֲלֵיהֶם כְּמַעֲשֵׂה הַצְדִּיקִים, – and yet with all this, in this world there are wicked people who receive what seems fitting for the righteous, and vice versa. – And our Sages of blessed memory stated (Berakhot 7b) concerning a wicked person for whom the hour prospers: "וְאֵיךְ אֶפְשָׁר זֶה, וְהֵלֵא כָּל מִשְׁפָּטֵי אֱמֶת, – "Your judgments are on high, out of his sight," – "מְרוֹם מִשְׁפָּטֶיךָ מִנְּגִדוֹ?" – and how is this possible, when all His judgments are Truth? – רַק דְּבִאֲמָתָא אֵין לֵךְ אֶדָם שְׂאֵין בּוֹ זְכוּת וְחוֹבָה. – Rather, in truth there is no person who does not contain both merit and culpability, – אֶפְלוּ, – וְכִמּוּ שְׂאֵמָרוּ: "אֶפְלוּ, – and "there is no righteous man upon earth who [does good and sins not]." – וְעֵנִין שְׂקוּל הַזְּכוּתִּים וְהַעֲבֵרוֹת. – And the weighing of merits against transgressions – בְּכָר כְּתֵב הַרְמָב"ם, – was already articulated by Maimonides in Hilchot Teshuvah: they are weighed solely in Hashem's knowledge; – וְיִצְחָק פְּתָגָם, כִּי אֵין בְּזֶה דִּיעָה כָּלָל, – and the matter is solid, for man has no comprehension of this calculation whatsoever; – אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁרְבוּחֵינוּ וְזָרוּנָם;

¹⁷ **Yoma 39a** — Our Rabbis taught: "And you shall sanctify yourselves and be holy." If a man sanctifies himself a little, they sanctify him greatly; if he sanctifies himself below, they sanctify him from above; if he sanctifies himself in this world, they sanctify him for the World to Come. **Rashi**: "And you shall sanctify yourselves": a little; "and you shall be holy": greatly. One who comes to purify himself is assisted. **Maharal (Nesivos Olam, Nesiv HaTzedek 2)**: [Just as with defilement a man's own act counts as little, since he is a creature of body, yet he is defiled greatly on the side of the soul, from above,] so too with purity and holiness: if a man sanctifies himself a little (for man's deeds are deeds of the body, and that is only a little) they sanctify him greatly from above. And if a man sanctifies himself in this world, they sanctify him in the World to Come, which is the supreme holiness above all; understand, then, how when a man sanctifies himself in holiness, they sanctify him with a supreme holiness.

¹⁸ **Berakhot 7b** — R. Yitzchak said: If you see a wicked man upon whom the hour is smiling, do not contend with him, as it is said, "His ways prosper at all times." And more than that — he prevails in judgment, as it is said, "Your judgments are far above him." And more than that — he sees his foes fall, as it is said, "As for all his adversaries, he snorts at them." **Rashi**: "His ways prosper" — yachilu means they succeed, as in "therefore his prosperity shall not endure" (Job 20:21). "Your judgments are far above him" — Your judgments are removed far away from him; and "he snorts at them" means that with his very breath he drives them off like straw. **Maharsha**: His prosperity is certainly only for an hour, as that psalm itself says, "for they shall soon wither like grass" and "yet a little while and the wicked is no more" — it is the fortune of the hour that does it for him. And "his ways prosper at all times" likewise means all that time in which his fortune prospers him; it is from the words "at all times" that R. Yitzchak inferred that a man must beware of him, in law and in provocation alike, for as long as his ways prosper through the fortune of the hour. **Maharal (Nesivos Olam, Nesiv HaShalom 3)**: They came to teach that contention is a very ugly trait, but that it is not ugly everywhere, for strife with the wicked and with those who forsake the Torah is good. When the matter is one of Heaven, then he should contend with the wicked man — when the hour is not smiling upon him. **Rav Tzadok (Ohr Zarua LaTzaddik, Thirteen Principles of Conduct 12)**: One upon whom the hour smiles prevails in the judgment of Heaven, being judged as righteous for the time being. So too in human judgment, pleading for mercy is effective even before a court and a Sanhedrin, for through it he may prevail in judgment: not that they will pervert the judgment, but that their eyes will be opened to find merit, since in every matter there is a scale of merit and a scale of guilt. And now that there is no Sanhedrin, Heavenly judgment, the judgment of the four death penalties and other punishments have still not ceased, and through mercy he prevails in judgment and goes free.

– even though our Sages noted in various passages: "this mitzvah is greater than that one," – **that applies generally according to the Torah's legal framework, אָבֵל מִשְׁפָּט שְׁלֵמָעֵלָה כְּפִי פְרָטִי הַנִּפְשׁוֹת, אִין שׁוּם נָפֶשׁ דּוֹמָה לַחֲבֵרוֹ – whereas supernal judgment regarding individual souls treats no two souls alike.** וְהוּא הַחֲלוּקִים דְּמִזְלָא שְׁאִין תְּלוֹי – And this is the distinction of mazal not depending on generic merit: – **And this is the distinction of mazal not depending on generic merit: – that even if both individuals are complete tzaddikim identical in their deeds, מְכַל – nevertheless, in this one the power of that advocating angel is aroused by specific merits – מקום אֶצֶל זֶה מִתְעוֹכֵר כִּחַ אוֹתוֹ מֵלֶאךָ מְלִיץ עַל יְדֵי זְכוּת וְיָדוּעוֹת – to pour down upon him an influx of children, life, and sustenance from his supernal mazal, וְלֹא אֶצֶל זֶה – while in that one it is not; אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁעָשָׂה גַם בֵּן אוֹתוֹן זְכוּת – and even though he performed those exact same merits. – nevertheless, when judged according to the unique root of his mazal, he is evaluated differently.** – **And likewise conversely among the wicked: there are instances of "Your judgments are on high," שְׁאִין – where strict justice lacks the immediate mandate to punish him during that hour when fortune smiles upon him, כִּחַ בְּמִדַּת מִשְׁפָּט לְדוֹנוֹ עַל רִשְׁעוֹ בְּאוֹתָהּ שָׁעָה הַמְשַׁחֶקֶת לוֹ מִצַּד אֵיזָה זְכוּת הַמַּרְעִישׁ כִּנְגָדָם וּמַחֲפָה עַל הַכֹּל לְפִי – owing to some extraordinary merit that clamors on his behalf and shields everything for that hour's judgment. – And these matters are vast concerning the supernal pathways of judgment, touching the deep secrets of the cosmos. – And the guiding rule is: everything proceeds by exact justice, וְהַקָּלִל: דֶּהכֹּל בְּמִשְׁפָּט – and with all that, it remains dependent upon mazal— תְּלוֹי בְּמִזְלָא – for the judicial evaluation of merits and debts regarding the drawing down of children, life, and sustenance in this world is determined by the soul's mazal.**

Seif 2 - Prayer above Mazal

Prayer reaches beyond the soul's fixed root, while Purim's mitzvot draw Torah, life, sustenance, and continuity into the world.

– **As for prayer, concerning which our Sages of blessed memory said (Berakhot 6b) שֶׁהוּא מִדְּבָרִים הַעוֹמְדִים בְּרוּמוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם – that it is among the matters standing at the height of the world, הֵינּוּ בַּמָּקוֹם הַמִּזְלָא שֶׁהוּא מְרֻמָּם מַעֲנֵן הָעוֹלָם הַזֶּה כְּפִיזָר, – this means at the level of mazala, the soul's supernal root, which transcends the affairs of this world, as mentioned. וְהֵינּוּ כִּי – and וְזֶה כֹּל שׁוֹרֵשׁ עֲנֵן הַתְּפִלָּה; – **Prayer brings about changes in mazala; the soul's supernal root, which transcends the affairs of this world, as mentioned. – this is the entire foundation of prayer: mazala receives and delights in the radiance of the Divine Presence, כִּי הַמִּזְלָא הוּא הַמִּקְבֵּל וְנִהְיָה מִזִּיו הַשְּׂכִינָה – whereas prayer is addressed to the One who bestows that abundance, blessed be His Name. – According to the strength of the abundance bestowed from above, הַמִּזְלָא נִגְדַּת הַמִּזְלָא – so are the changes in children, life, and sustenance, contrary to what one's mazal would otherwise determine. – this means that through prayer, which increases the abundance, הַרִי מִמִּילָא מְזֹל עֲצָמוֹ מִשְׁפִּיעַ לוֹ זֶה מִה שֶׁלֹּא הָיָה – his own mazal consequently bestows upon him what he previously lacked.****

¹⁹ **Berakhot 6b** — One of the Sages said to Rav Beivai bar Abaye, and some say Rav Beivai said to Rav Nachman bar Yitzchak: What is "when vileness is exalted among the sons of men"? He said to him: These are matters that stand at the summit of the world, and men treat them lightly. **Rashi:** "When vileness is exalted" — this is the end of the verse cited above ["The wicked walk round about"]. "Matters that stand at the summit of the world" — such as prayer, which ascends on high. **Maharsha:** It is evident that this refers back to the opening of the verse: one who prays around the synagogue, that is, outside it, is called wicked, because he treats prayer lightly — and prayer is among "the matters that stand at the summit of the world." **Mei HaShiloach (vol. II, Tehillim 34):** Although in human eyes the deed seems to be the main thing, the chief guarding is truly of the mouth and tongue, for everything is clarified through the tongue — as the Baal Shem Tov explained the Gemara's "things that stand at the height of the world": it is words [spoken words] that stand at the height of the world. As the holy Zohar says, "once he has brought a word out of his mouth, that word becomes a voice, splits the airs and firmaments, and rises on high."